

Shadow to Steel

Obedience, Iron, and the Return of the King

Glenn Michael

The King does not return the same as
when he left. He returns forged in the
fire of obedience.

Soul of an Explorer, Heart of a Warrior

*I walked through the Valley where the shadows grow deep,
Carried the lies till I could barely sleep.
They tried to break me, rewrite who I am,
The fire refined and I became a new man.*

Soul of an explorer, heart of a warrior!

*I kneel to the King of Kings, then I rise like a warrior!
Three Kingdoms I raise, in the order divine,
This is my battle – the steel is mine!
No false guilt, no living the lies,
No bowing down while strong men die.
I was born of the fire, I fight the good fight,
I kneel before God, then I stand in the light.*

Soul of an explorer, heart of a warrior!

*I kneel to the King of Kings, then I rise like a warrior!
Let the culture come screaming, let them call me insane,
I'm the Third Kind of Man – hear the roar of His name!
From the black marble prison to the forge and the flame,
I reclaimed my soul I am not the same.
Every scar is a story, every fall made me tall,
I'm the man who surrendered. . . I answered His call.*

Soul of an explorer, heart of a warrior!

I kneel to the King of Kings – The Three Kingdoms rise and forever stand tall

Foreword

For decades I lived as a man that had unknowingly surrendered his sovereignty through misplaced trust, false guilt, cultural pressures and un-examined patterns. I watched as the culture demanded lifting women while at the same time denigrating men. I carried burdens that were never mine to carry absorbing false narratives of masculinity, lowered boundaries in the name of love, and pretended endurance was the same as strength. Then came the Valley of the Shadow: betrayal, marital stress, illness – and a body turning against itself. In July 2022, diagnosed with relapsing polychondritis, knee surgery, hip replacement, nasal reconstruction, destruction of my chest cartilage, lung damage, I sat in a recliner and faced the simple, terrifying truth:

“I was born, and I will die. ”

“Lord, tell me what to do and I will do it,” that was the heart of my prayer, the supplication that He answered immediately: "Bench, Squat, Deadlift."

That night I rose as a man who had finally knelt. This book, *Shadow to Steel*, tells the story of that journey — from the Valley of the Shadow, through the refiner’s fire, to steel – and issues a clear call to every man, both young and old, who sense that the modern world is offering a counterfeit version of masculinity, an inversion of the natural order, and toxic femininity. Feminism has destroyed the relationship between men and women, peddles a false narrative that all men are toxic and all women are victims, has turned our society and its governing institutions into a hyper-emotional state, devoid of logic and common sense. In short, it is driving our society over the cliff.

Our culture is full of loud, performative Kings – false kings – Jesters really. They flex on screens, chase validation, and bend the knee to every appetite, algorithm, and trend. They claim Kingship but they possess no throne. Their strength is illusion. Their crowns, cap 'n' bells – a fool’s cap. True Kingship is the opposite – It begins on the knees in submission to the King of Kings. Only then will men reclaim their rightful place as the leaders society desperately needs.

Jesus Christ, the ultimate Third Kind of Man, showed us the way. He knelt in Gethsemane under the weight of the cup. He knelt to wash the feet of His disciples — including Judas, whom He knew would betray Him. He emptied Himself completely, and because He knelt in perfect obedience, He rose with an authority that the "gates of hell cannot prevail against" Matthew 16:18.

This is the paradox at the heart of the book: the man who refuses to kneel will eventually kneel to something lesser. The man who kneels before the King of Kings rises with steel that cannot be broken by the world.

In the pages that follow, I share honestly how this truth reshaped my life — the black marble room dream that prepared me, the recliner epiphany that relit a forge long grown cold, the rebuilding of body betrayed by itself, the protection and provision of the my family, and the long difficult restoration of my marriage – an effort that continues. None of it came easily. All of it came through surrender.

The heart of the message is this: you do not have to wait until the Valley of The Shadow nearly destroys you. Start kneeling now. The Catholic Church gives you everything required — the sacraments (especially Confession and the Eucharist), the Scriptures, the Saints, and the living tradition that can only come from an unbroken line of Apostolic succession.

Become the Third Kind of Man: fall hard if you must, be refined in the fire, and rise to rule your proper realms in order:

The Spiritual Kingdom first and highest (Submission to The Catholic Church) The Kingdom of Sovereignty as the inner throne (an unapologetic masculine frame, no-bid mindset, steel identity) The Physical Kingdom as the forge (Iron Church, body, Marriage Sovereignty, daily life)

This is not abstract theology. It is a practical, embodied frame of living for men who want to fight the good fight and leave a legacy of steel instead of regret. Men: the culture wants you soft, distracted, and wearing a jester's costume. Christ calls you to something greater – to choose the "refiner's fire", choose the forge, and kneel before the King of Kings.

I struggle, raising and ruling each Kingdom is not for the faint of heart. But, each day is an opportunity to raise each Kingdom higher. Make no mistake, the culture will come for you, the enforcers of the culture will denigrate you, call you names, take from you what they can as punishment. If you refuse to give them power, then they can only take things, they cannot take your spirit, your dignity, your honor, your strength or your relationship with God. For, the King that kneels before the King of Kings is the King that rules sovereign over his Three Kingdoms.

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Chapter 1

The Black Marble Room

4 There is only one thing I ask of the Lord, just one thing I seek; to dwell in the house of the Lord all the days of my life, so that I may enjoy the beauty of the Lord and gaze on his temple. 5 For he will hide me in his shelter in times of trouble. He will conceal me under the cover of his tent and place me high upon his rock. 13 I am confident that I will behold the goodness of the Lord in the land of the living. 14 Place your hope in the Lord: be strong and courageous in your heart, and place your hope in the Lord. – Psalm 27:4-5, 13-14

Five years before the recliner, before the diagnosis, before the voice, I was already in the Valley of the Shadow of Death. I just didn't know the name for it yet.

Nothing was going right.

- I had been wrongfully terminated from my job, my restricted stock awards, spitefully canceled. I lost a significant amount of wealth.
- Shortly afterward, lightning struck our home. The top floor burned. The lower floor flooded from the firefighting efforts. Most of the house was destroyed.
- Having lost my job, the person that had driven the termination was using the full legal weight of the bank which I had worked to blacklist me, I began an independent consultancy which required me to be away from home five to six days a week,
- My family relationships began to fray under the strain.

Living alone in cheap hotel rooms sinking with neither an end nor aid in sight the weight of it all became unbearable. One night, I cried out to the Lord with raw desperation: "Lord, I cannot bear this any longer. If there is an end to it, please let me know. If not, at least tell me that too, so I can resign myself to this trap."

That night I had the most vivid dream of my life.

I stood in a vast, windowless chamber carved from a single block of polished black marble. The walls and floor were seamless, cold, reflective - like night itself made solid. There was no door, no window, no visible exit. Far above, impossibly high in the ceiling, a tiny opening let in a faint shaft of light. It might as well have been on the moon.

I tried to climb. I wedged my body into the smooth corners, straining upward, but the marble offered no grip. Even if I gained height, exhaustion would have pulled me back down to my death.

Defeated and breathing hard, a simple marble bench appeared behind me. I sat down and told myself, "Don't panic. You're a smart person. You can figure this out."

Then I felt a presence to my left — masculine, calm, and authoritative — yet I could never see Him directly. He remained just beyond the edge of my vision, always slightly out of sight. In a quiet, steady voice He said, "We have decided to show you how this is going to end."

He led me to the left-most corner of the room — the very corner I had already examined and found nothing. Now there was a doorway. Behind it stretched a long hallway lined with identical black marble doors on both sides. We walked until He stopped at one and said, "This is your door."

I opened it and stepped into a smaller black marble room, identical to the first. In the center, on a raised pedestal, sat a golden tabernacle — exactly like the one that holds the Eucharist in church. I opened the doors and looked inside.

I cannot describe what I saw. I can only tell you the single overwhelming thought that flooded me: That's not so bad.

I stepped back into the hallway. The presence was still there. We walked to the far end and exited. I was back in the original large chamber. The marble bench remained, but the doorway and hallway had vanished. Only the tiny unreachable light high above remained.

I sat down again, still trying to solve the puzzle, and then I woke up.

I never forgot that dream. It was the first quiet answer to a prayer I had not yet fully prayed. Seven years later, when I sat in the recliner facing what looked like certain death, the Lord had already shown me the truth: even in the most sealed, lightless chamber, a way out existed — if I was willing to wait, to listen, and to obey.

The dream was the seed planted in darkness. The prayer — "tell me what to do and I will do it" — became the vow.

And the iron would become the path.

I would come to realize, that I was walking through the valley of the shadow of death. But, before that realization came to me another was to precede — the Book of Job.

The Book of Job is one of the oldest and most profound books in the Bible. It is not primarily about why "bad things happen to good people." It is about **faith under extreme testing** - whether a man will serve God for who God is, or only for the blessings he receives. The story opens in Heaven with a dialog between God and Satan. God points out Job as "blameless and upright, a man who fears God and shuns evil." Satan immediately accuses Job of conditional faith: "Does Job fear God for nothing?" That is to say, Satan claims Job only serves God because God has built a protective hedge of blessing around Job.

God then permits Satan to test Job - but with strict limits. Satan cannot kill Job or take his life. Everything else is on the table. The story illustrates that Satan does not attack randomly. Rather, Satan uses a systematic, multi-layered strategy designed to break Job's faith from every direction. And rest assured Satan will use the same strategy with each and every person. Satan's attack vectors as outlined in chapters one through two are outlined below:

1. Economic - Livelihood Destruction (Job 1:14-17)

- Sabeans steal oxen and donkeys and kill servants.
- Fire from heaven burns the sheep and shepherds.
- Chaldeans steal camels and kill more servants.

Satan wipes out Job's entire wealth and business in one day. The goal: remove security and provision.

2. Family - Emotional Devastation (Job 1:18-19)

- A great wind collapses the house where all ten of Job's children are feasting and kills everyone of them.

Satan removes Job's entire legacy and support system in a single moment. The goal: crush the heart.

3. Physical - Bodily Affliction (Job 2:7-8)

- Satan strikes Job with painful sores from the soles of his feet to the top of his head.

Job is left scraping himself with broken pottery while sitting in ashes. The goal: constant, unrelenting torment that makes every moment miserable

4. Relations - Social Isolation (Job 2:9-10 and throughout)

- Job's wife tells him to "Curse God and die."
- Job's three friends (and later Elihu) arrive, but instead of comfort they accuse Job of hidden sin and judge him relentlessly for 30+ chapters.

Satan turns the people closest to Job into sources of pain and accusation. The goal: total loneliness.

5. Spiritual - Psychological Attack (the entire of the book)

- Job is plunged into deep despair, questioning why he was ever born, feeling abandoned by God, and wrestling with the apparent injustice of it all.

Satan attacks the mind and the spirit, trying to drive Job to curse God. The goal: break the relationship with God

I had no understanding at the time that I was living through the very same multi-layered attack Satan had used against Job. In my ignorance, I simply fought harder to keep my head above water. The more I struggled, the deeper I sank into a darkness I could not name or escape. I was already walking through the valley of the shadow of death.

What I did not yet realize was that the Valley was also the forge.

Chapter 2

The Valley – The Place of Shadow and Fear

2 My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why have you paid no heed to my cry for help, to my cries of anguish? 3 O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer, by night, but I am afforded no relief. 20 But you, O lord, do not remain aloof from me; O my Strength, come quickly to my aid. – Psalm 22:2-3,20

Psalm 22 was written by King David around 1000 – 970 BC during one of his darkest periods. Most scholars believe it was composed while he was on the run during the rebellion of his own son Absalom. At the time, David was hunted, betrayed by his closest advisor, publicly humiliated, and utterly alone — living in the valley of the shadow of death.

I knew exactly how he felt.

For years the misfortune had been grinding me down. I felt a complete emotional disconnect in my marriage, and now the marriage that once anchored me had grown indifferent and hostile. I prayed the same desperate question David did: My God, why have you abandoned me? At first I convinced myself the Lord had left because I was unworthy – I hadn't been to church in years. Then I began to wonder if God existed at all. Neither thought brought comfort.

Standing alone on the train platform into town, the sky darkened by heavy clouds. It was cold and damp, and a stinging bitter wind whipped across my face. At that moment I had an epiphany: this is exactly how my inner world felt. Yet I continued to pray. I still believed in God. I still sought comfort from the Lord. The devastating truth was not that God did not exist, but that I could no longer feel His presence. And I had no idea that I would have to walk through the valley of the shadow of death before I would feel it again.

The Summer of 2021, I was walking through the valley- I didn't fully recognize it. June. Middle of the season, yet I wore a hoodie outdoors because I was freezing down to my core. My right knee had been painful and swollen for six months due to a torn meniscus. - how it happened was beyond me. After repeated cortisone injections, insurance finally approved surgery. During the follow-up the surgeon told me he had sent fluid from my knee for cancer testing—it looked that abnormal. The result came back negative. Only

later visit would he realize the fluid was classic for the autoimmune disease that was already destroying me.

Physical therapy after knee surgery brought new pain in my left hip. Within weeks I could barely walk. The hip surgeon showed me comparative X-rays: the cartilage in my left hip had been completely erased while the right hip remained unchanged. "What could do something like that?" I asked. He had no answer.

Then came the dry cough and shortness of breath – constant, unnatural. Interns and nurses noticed it. The hip replacement itself triggered a major flare. Nasal cartilage was destroyed, leaving me with a saddle-nose deformity. The shortness of breath and chest pain continued. I bought a Peloton, mostly to help build leg strength following the two surgeries and I believe the shortness of breath convinced me it was due to poor conditioning - little did I know that the kind of shortness of breath I was experiencing was a classic autoimmune symptom. Every ride became a battle: coughing, gasping, fighting an invisible enemy that was killing me slowly, methodically, day by day.

January 2022, late one night I was lying in bed facing the truth: a silent killer was winning. I turned to the Lord with a simple, stripped-down prayer: "Lord, something is killing me. All I want is to know - what it is. Please get me in front of someone who can tell me before I die."

The next morning, in that quiet twilight between sleep and waking, a voice—not my own—spoke with calm authority:

"Don't worry about work, don't worry about insurance, just call everyone you can and take whatever appointment is available—today, tomorrow, a month, a year from now - It doesn't matter."

I started with the obvious: my ruined nose. I called ENT offices until, on the fifth try, a cheerful woman at Rush University answered. "You're in luck—we just reopened this week." She booked me with the department's top specialist, Dr. Papagiannopoulos.

A week later, I was sitting in the exam room waiting for the doctor. Once he arrived and we traded pleasantries, I went over the litany of maladies that had befallen me, each in its proper order. I dropped the surgical mask they had given me to wear at admittance showing him the saddle nose deformity and said - "then this happened." He replied, "I am sorry that happened to you." This was the first time anyone had expressed sympathy for the deformity that had befallen me. After which, he immediately referred me to rheumatology.

That same day, I met Dr. Block. He entered the exam room, looked me over and asked who referred me. I replied, Dr. Papagiannopoulos, he nodded in approval. I had managed to find the right doctor, one that could see the seriousness of my situation, and who would in turn refer me rightly to another that would help me - my prayer had been answered.

Dr. Block agreed, we needed to repair my nose. A biopsy was needed to aid in the identification of the disease. Over the course of the next six months, while waiting for my nasal reconstruction, I returned to Rush on a monthly basis for routine examinations and blood draws. During this time I met Doctor Revenaugh the surgeon that would repair my nose. Initially, he indicated that he would repair the saddle deformity but not the hole in the septum. I explained to him, I realized the septum repair had at best an 80

percent success rate but even in the case of a failure it is an improvement. I asked him to try, if it does not fully succeed that is fine at least we tried. He agreed to try.

The surgery went forward, I splints in my nose to protect the repair work to my septum, they would remain for the summer. The chest cartilage recovered to repair the saddle deformity was, as Dr. Revenaugh put it - 'barely viable'. The disease had destroyed my chest cartilage. Fortunately, it had remodeled itself into a fibrous tissue, something they had never seen before; I had been spared the fate of a 'loose chest', which is common in these instances.

On my next visit in July they delivered the diagnosis Relapsing Polychondritis; until the surgery the disease had been running at a constant low level - insidious - making it unidentifiable. It had impacted the cartilage in my right knee, destroyed the cartilage in my nose, chest, left hip, and was now slowly destroying the cartilage in my respiratory tract and trachea.

My childhood asthma returned and breathing became increasingly difficult. Doctor Block referred me for a pulmonary test. At the follow up, I met doctor Vashi, she began treating me for both my resurgent asthma as well as the damage done to my respiratory tract.

The diagnosis landed like a sentence: Relapsing Polychondritis. I now knew the name of the silent killer that had been destroying me piece by piece. My earlier prayer had been answered. In the recliner that July evening, the weight of it settled fully. I was going to die.

After a few minutes the fear gave way to clarity. I had already walked through the valley. I had already seen the black marble room. I had already heard the first quiet answer. In that moment I prayed as David once did in Psalm 22:

I confessed my sins against the Lord. I apologized for the arrogance of believing everything I had accomplished was by my own strength instead of recognizing those things as blessings from Him. Then I made no bargain — only a vow.

"If it is my time, then it is my time. If it is not my time, tell me what to do to fix myself, and I will do it."

The next morning, in the twilight between sleep and waking, the voice returned — calm and unmistakable:

"Bench, Squat Deadlift."

For those unfamiliar with powerlifting, these are the Big Three — the foundational compound lifts. For a man whose cartilage was being systematically destroyed by disease, the prescription sounded absurd. Yet in that moment, I understood: this was not a miracle. This was a path. This was the forge — the forge I knew so well from childhood.

The Valley had shown me the darkness. The Lord had shown me the way out. Now the iron would become the fire that would refine the shadow of death into steel.

Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me. — Psalm 23:4-5

The Lord heard my cries and answered — not with a miracle, but with a prescription. I was to step from the valley of the shadow of death into the forge that refines, and I knew the Lord was with me.

Chapter 3

The Forge – The Fire That Refines

2 But who will be able to endure the day of his coming, and who can stand when he appears?
For he is like a refiner's fire or fuller's soap. 3 He will sit refining and purifying: he will purify the descendants of Levi and refine them like gold and silver. so that they may in righteousness offer due sacrifice to the Lord. –
Malachi 3:2-3

I have known the fire of the forge longer than I realized. As a child, I suffered from severe asthma. Each day was the same: some days were manageable, others a struggle. But the nights were different. I would wake in the late hours gasping for air, chest tight, lungs constricted. Some nights I would pass out from lack of oxygen. Other nights I would collapse from exhaustion simply trying to breathe.

I never complained. I just kept going.

Years later, my Uncle Mike — who suffers from COPD — reflected on those days after Sunday brunch. He looked at me and said, “My sister once told me, you never complained about your asthma. You just kept going.”

He was right. Even then, without knowing its name of purpose, I was already walking through the first forge. The same enemy that would later attack my cartilage, my marriage, and my peace was already testing me in the quiet hours of childhood. He could not break me then, and he would not break me later.

As a child, I would often pray to the Lord, why this affliction, why me? Always, to no answer, not because the Lord did not hear my prayer but because the prayer itself was not correct – rather than asking the Lord for assistance I questioned Him. I resolved myself to overcome my affliction, I began running; working myself up to a 6-1/2 minute mile. I participated in mini-marathons, training marathon distance, weight training. Overtime, through fortitude and determination I got stronger. I convinced myself that the Lord was an observer and not a participant in my life. I drifted from the Church and came to despise any weakness in myself - weakness was something to remedied at all costs.

I realized that the purpose of the first forge was to develop the determination and will that would enable me to withstand the fire of the second forge. I slowly returned to Church, prayed my Rosary daily and I began to understand:

The adversity we face has a purpose. The Bible does not frame adversity and suffering as an accident. It treats it as a deliberate refining process. The prophet Malachi describes the Lord as a refiner's fire:

"But who can endure the day of his coming? Who can stand when he appears? For he is like a refiner's fire... He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver." (Malachi 3:2-3).

The fire does not destroy the silver – it burns away the dross so that what remains is pure. The furnace does not consume the gold – it separates the impurities so the metal can be shaped and used.

The same principle appears again and again throughout Scripture. Job was stripped of everything so his faith could be proven genuine. David cried out in the Valley of the Shadow and emerged declaring God's name in the great assembly. Peter wrote that these trials come " so that the proven genuineness of your faith — of greater worth than gold, which perishes even though refined by fire — may result in praise, glory and honor when Jesus Christ is revealed " (1 Peter 1:7). The Forge is not random suffering. It is the deliberate, holy fire of the Refiner. The Lord does not watch from a distance — He is in the fire with us:

This is the ancient pattern repeated throughout Scripture. Isaiah declares, " See, I have refined you, though not as silver; I have tested you in the furnace of affliction " (Isaiah 48:10). Zechariah promises the Lord will put His people through the fire " and refine them as silver is refined, and test them as gold is tested " (Zechariah 13:9). Peter tells us these trials come so that " the proven genuineness of your faith—of greater worth than gold, which perishes even though refined by fire—may result in praise, glory and honor when Jesus Christ is revealed " (1 Peter 1:6–7). The Forge is not punishment.

It is purification. The enemy attacks which is most important — first a man's spirit and then his physical strength — thinking he will break the man. But every blow he lands only turns up the heat of the Forge that the Lord Himself placed us in. The small god of this world believes he is destroying us. The King knows he is only intensifying the refining process. More dross is burned away and the steel that emerges is unbreakable.

Nothing the enemy takes is beyond the Lord's reach. Job, stripped of everything, declared, "But he knows the way that I take; when he has tested me, I will come forth as gold" (Job 23:10). David walked through the Valley of the Shadow and emerged declaring God's name in the great assembly. The same fire that tested them is the fire that tested me.

The prescription had been given and the path was clear "Bench, Squat, Deadlift" it required surrender to the will of the Lord – obedience in the face of adversity.

The Forge and faith are not separate. They are locked in a living covenant. The fire tests the faith, and the faith steps willingly into the fire. Each strengthens the other. The Lord does not call us to passive endurance. He calls us to active obedience inside the furnace. This is why the voice in the recliner did not say "pray harder" or "wait for healing." It said something far more demanding. The command: "Bench, Squat, Deadlift" was the birth of my Iron Church — the physical expression of faith when everything in the body is screaming to quit. The Forge is the fire and the Iron Church is the expression of faith and together they shape the man.

Faith (Jesus's Church) without the Iron Church becomes soft and theoretical, Iron Church without Jesus's Church becomes mere exercise and pride. But, when the two are yoked together, iron sharpens iron (Proverbs 27:17). Each strengthens the other, a man become whole and something unbreakable is formed; and men rise to that for which they were made.

Once one begins to understand this, every rep, every set, every mile on the treadmill becomes an act of worship. Each time the body wants to stop and the will chooses to continue, faith is proven genuine and the dross is burned away. The enemy thought he could destroy me by attacking the body. Instead, I was driven deeper into the Forge and forced me to build the very thing that would make me stronger — deeper faith God Church yoked to the Iron Church.

This is the mystery of the refining fire: the hotter the flame, the stronger the steel. The greater the adversity, the deeper the faith. The two do not oppose each other. They complete each other.

The Valley had shown me the darkness. What I did not yet fully understand was that the Valley itself had become the Forge. The same place of despair and near-death had been transformed into the crucible where steel is made. The prescription was not an escape from the fire — it was the fire. The iron would do what medicine alone could not: rebuild the body, sharpen the mind, and temper the spirit:

The Lord did not remove me from the Valley, He changed the Valley into the Forge, And in that Forge, the Iron Church was born.

Chapter 4

The Nature of God, Three Types of Men, Man's Biblical Role

1 In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God, 2 He was with God in the very beginning, 3 Through Him all things came into existence, and without Him there was nothing. – John 1:1-3

The Valley became the Forge. The Forge called forth the Iron Church. But the fire does not stop at the weight room.

Today every man faces a different kind of fire — one that is quieter, more pervasive, and more dangerous to the soul of masculinity. It is the systematic feminization of culture and the relentless social engineering that seeks to weaken men, soften their nature, confuse their identity, and convince them that their strength itself is the problem – this is the great refining fire of our time.

4.1 The Nature of God

God did not create weak, uncertain, compliant men. He created men with strength, purpose, courage, and responsibility. The current age despises this design. It calls strength toxic, leadership oppression, and stoicism emotional damage. It spins the straw of fairy tales into ideology that tells women the very nature of men is the problem. The cultural fire must be faced, men must reject the narrative and society's attempt to feminize and weaken them. Men cannot succeed in this endeavor alone – they must turn to their creator, God the Father Almighty, and the Church of Jesus, the Catholic Church.

At the dawn of the 21st Century men seek purpose. They ask for purpose in their work and in their lives. To these men, to quote Winston Churchill, their purpose has become "a riddle, wrapped in a mystery, inside an enigma. " Why? Why so difficult for men to understand their purpose?

The answer to the above question is simple – Modernity. One hallmark characteristic, and some would argue, the defining characteristic of modernity is the relentless push to secularization. That is, the removal of God, Christianity, and the sacred from public

institutions, law, education, and culture. The era of modernity began sometime around the 15th through 18th century and continues to the present day.

Indeed, Friedrich Nietzsche recognized the problem of modernity when he first wrote the famous phrase "God is dead" in his book "The Gay (Joyful) Science." Nietzsche argues that "Enlightenment Science", dismantled the foundation of Christian morality. He realized, with God "dead," the entire foundation of Western morality, meaning, and values collapses leading to nihilism – a world without objective meaning; unless humanity could create new values to replace the Christian values. – humanity failed.

God is the uncaused-cause of the Universe. The Creator who spoke the universe into existence with precision and purpose. He is the Refiner who sits over the fire. He disciplines those He loves. He does not guarantee an easy life. He guarantees a meaningful one — a life where a man can choose eternal life – through worship, prayer, and discipline. Still modernity demands proof of God's existence – **the arrogance of Enlightenment**.

4.1.1 The Proof of God

The Fine Tuning Argument, posits the probability that the rules which govern physics and the universe arose by pure randomness is astonishingly small – so small in fact as to be zero. The physical constants of our universe are tuned with extraordinary precision to support the existence of life, stars, chemistry, and stable matter. Thus, all of creation reflects intelligent design. Fine tuning adherents point to reality as proof:

- The cosmological constant (dark energy density), fine tuned to roughly 1 part in 10^{120} .
- The precise strength of the nuclear force.
- The ratio of the electromagnetic force to gravity.
- The exact mass of the electron and other fundamental principles.

4.1.2 Hypothesis Seeking to Disprove God

1. **The Multiverse Hypothesis** posits a universe creating process which spews forth countless other universes. Thus, given a process that continually creates one random universe after another it is likely that one will come forth that will support intelligent life. The idea that our universe is merely one of countless others created with random constraints fails on several fronts:

- By what mechanism do these universes come forth? There is no known mechanism capable of generating truly random universes with varying laws. And, if such a mechanism does exist what is its cause?
- The problem of coexistence: how do infinite universes exist without collision or interference? A question whose answer would reduce to a finely tuned process.
- Lack of elegance: Infinite redundancy does not reflect supreme intelligence – it reflects insecurity. A truly sovereign Creator would have no need for backup plans.

2. **Deeper Underlying Law** suggests the constants are inevitable due to some yet-undiscovered mathematical necessity. However, this merely pushes the question back – where did the deeper underlying law originate, and why is it life-permitting.
3. **Simulation Hypothesis** proposes that all of reality is an artificial simulation run by higher beings. Further it argues, that these "higher beings" run numerous simulations and our simulation is but one of many. Sound familiar? It is *prima facie* absurd and the fact that any person gives it serious consideration speaks to the weakness of humanity. It is easily debunked. First, if higher beings are running simulations how did they come to existence? Second, if we lived in a simulation, conscious beings would be equivalent to sophisticated AIs. This contradicts the persistent subjective experience of human consciousness – the divine spark.

Each of the above hypothesis seeking to disprove God reflect the nihilism Nietzsche warned about with his famous phrase "God is dead." Indeed, the simulation hypothesis reflects peak nihilism reducing human consciousness to a computer program.

4.1.3 Proof of God – The Elegant Design

Proof of God – The Elegant Design We can frame the question directly and simply. There are two main explanations for why the universe exists the way it does:

Explanation 0: The physical constants are the result of pure chance. No intelligence or purpose is behind them. Explanation 1: The physical constants were deliberately set by an intelligent cause so that life, chemistry, and complexity could exist.

Before we look at any evidence, a person might have some initial feeling about which explanation is more likely. Let's say someone starts fairly skeptical and thinks Explanation 1 (design) is only 1 in 5 as likely as Explanation 0 (chance). In odds form, that's 1 to 5. Now we look at the evidence: the extreme fine-tuning of the universe.

The constants that govern gravity, the strong nuclear force, the cosmological constant, and several others sit in an incredibly narrow range. If any one of them were changed by even a tiny amount, stars could not form, chemistry would not work, and life would be impossible. The chance of all these constants landing in the life-permitting range by accident is extraordinarily small — Roger Penrose's estimate of 1 part in 10^{120} for the cosmological constant is the probability (likelihood) that this constant would fall within the extremely narrow life-permitting range by pure chance. — 1 followed by 120 zeros — in plain terms: the evidence (fine-tuning) is vastly more likely if the constants were set on purpose than if they were random.

Using basic odds:

Start with prior odds of 1 to 5 in favor of design. The evidence multiplies those odds by a huge number (the Bayes factor). Even if we use a very conservative estimate and say the evidence is 1,000,000,000,000 times — 10^{12} — more likely under design, the math becomes:

$$\frac{1 \times 1,000,000,000,000}{5} = 200,000,000,000 \text{ to } 1$$

After seeing the evidence, design is now 200 billion to 1 more likely than pure chance. Even if someone started with extremely skeptical prior odds (say 1 to 100), the fine-tuning

evidence would still push the final odds overwhelmingly in favor of an intelligent cause. This is how rational belief updating works. The data doesn't just fail to support chance — it makes chance astronomically unlikely. The universe was calibrated.

Of course, one may look at this as overly simplified. However, take into consideration both the multiverse and the simulation hypothesis. Both claim to rely on statistics. Namely — 'The Law of Large Numbers' — given sufficient random trials the conditions for life are met. I have claimed earlier this is the peak nihilism of the Age of Enlightenment and it is worth repeating — the best the age of enlightenment can come up with is that each person is without value — the outcome of a sufficient number of trials.

4.2 The Three Kinds of Men

The Lord does not leave man's purpose ambiguous. Men are called to lead with courage, love sacrificially, protect fiercely, and build what is good.. They are not called to be soft, passive, or constantly seeking approval from a culture that despises him. The feminization of everything is not progress. It is a rebellion against God's design. The man who understands this does not bow to the propaganda of culture. He enters the Forge willingly.

1. **The First Kind of Man – The Man who has not failed.** He may appear strong and successful on the surface. However, he has avoided major failure, hardship, or public collapse. Often he is supported by a scaffolding that is unseen by others. But, because he has never been tested or experienced struggle and failure he often lacks depth, resilience — he avoids the forge. And, when real fire comes, he is frequently the first to break. He is the man that gives way to culture, he does not stand in the breach.
2. **The Second Kind of Man – The Man who falls and stays down.** Adversity hits him — disease, betrayal, failure, loss — and he remains on the ground. This man becomes bitter, defeated, or numb. He accepts victimhood or mediocrity as his permanent state. The forge consumes him instead of refining him.
3. **The Third Kind of Man – The man who falls and rises.** This is the rarest and strogest kind of man. He is knocked down by life —sometimes repeatedly — but he gets back up. He enters the Forge willingly. He submits to the fire. He allows God to burn away the weakness, the pride, the illusion. He is the man that wanders the Valley of the Shadow — he is the man that is forged in the refiner's fire from Shadow to Steel.

The third kind of man is anchored spiritually, is sovereign, and embraces his strength (physical nature). He does this not because the fire is easy but because the fire is real. The world desperately needs more of the third kind of man.

4.3 The Biblical Man

The Biblical Man is the man who has been tested and has risen.

Jesus is the perfect model. He was tempted in every way as we are, yet without sin (Hebrews 4:15). He was a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief (Isaiah 53:3). He sweat blood in Gethsemane, was betrayed by a friend, beaten, mocked, and nailed to a cross. He was knocked all the way down into death. And on the third day, He rose in power.

His masculinity was not soft. It was steel forged in obedience. He led, He protected, He sacrificed, He conquered, and He now reigns as King of Kings and Lord of Lords (Revelation 19:16).

The Biblical Man follows this pattern. He does not stay down when life knocks him to the ground. He enters the fire. He submits to the refining. He allows God to burn away what is weak and false. He rises — scarred, but stronger. Humble, but dangerous. He does not negotiate with a culture that despises his design. He does not apologize for his strength. He kneels before the King of Kings as a sovereign king, then rises to lead. He does not chase validation. He earns respect through obedience and steel. The Biblical Man has been through the Forge. He knows what it costs. And he chooses to rise anyway — because Jesus did.

And yet, behind the steel of the Biblical Man stands the undeniable reality of the God who calls him forth. As I have reflected in the pages of *Credo*, matter does not motivate itself. Inert substance cannot stir, cannot order itself into life, cannot ignite the fire of purpose or the breath of spirit. The universe, with all its intricate laws and ordered beauty, bears witness: there must be a First Mover, an Uncreated Creator who stands outside of matter, time, and space breathing life into what would otherwise remain cold and still. This is no abstract philosophy. This is the God who spoke light into darkness, who formed man from dust and breathed into him the breath of life. This is the God whose Son — the ultimate Third Kind of Man — entered the forge of suffering and emerged victorious. In Him we see both the proof and the pattern: God is not distant, but intimately involved in the refining of every man who will kneel and rise again.

Chapter 5

The King that Kneels

7 Hence, be subject to God, Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. 8 Draw near to God, and he will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you waverers. 9 Be sorrowful lament, and weep. Let your laughter turn to mourning and your joy to gloom. 10 Humble yourselves to the Lord and He will exalt you. – James 4:7-10

I sat in the recliner in the dim light of the living room, the weight of years pressing down like cold iron on my chest. It was July 2022. The diagnosis of relapsing polychondritis had just landed – my own body turning against itself, so cold I was wearing a hoodie in the middle of the summer, the fire inside me was dying and I was on my own. In a moment of clarity "I was born, so I will die; nothing has changed." I submitted to the Lord: if I am going to die then I am going to die, if not tell what to do to fix myself.

The answer came – not in thunder, but in three quiet words that would reshape everything: bench, squat, deadlift. Given my condition, it was not the response I expected from the God of the universe. Yet it was the beginning of everything. That night I didn't rise as a conquering hero. I rose as a man who had finally knelt.

True kingship has always begun on the knees.

The world trains us to picture kings on throne – crowns heavy, swords raised, commands made from elevated platforms. We imagine strength as dominance, leadership as control, masculinity as never bending. But Scripture paints a radically different portrait. The greatest King who ever walked the earth knelt in a garden, sweat like blood, submitting to a cup He did not want to drink. He knelt again to wash the feet of men who would soon abandon Him. And because He knelt, He rose with authority that hell itself could not shake.

This is the paradox of the Third Kind of Man: he falls hard, he is refined in the fire, and when he rises, he does so with knees still marked by the floor. He is no longer the happy fool who believed love meant lowering every boundary and strength meant pretending nothing hurt. He has seen the Valley. He has felt the Forge. Now he understands that real sovereignty flows from surrender.

Consider King David – warrior, poet, adulterer, murderer, man after God’s own heart. His greatest moments were never when he stood tallest, but when he lay prostrate. “Have mercy on me, O God,” he cried in Psalm 51, face to the ground. Or consider the centurion in Matthew 8, a man of authority who told Jesus, “I am not worthy to have you come under my roof.” His servant was healed because a powerful man chose to kneel in faith.

In the black marble room of my 2017 dream, I sat trapped on a bench, no apparent way out. He came to me and led me, showed me the way to passage. I stepped through and He led to see how it would all end; “Not so bad.” For years I carried that dream like a riddle. Only later did I see it clearly: Submission to the King of Kings raised me to the opening high above and freed me of the marble prison of my own making.

This is where many men break. Some want the crown without the kneeling, the steel without the refiner’s fire . We want sovereignty while still clutching control, especially in marriage, work, and health. I tried that path for decades. I played the happy fool in a marriage, tolerating accusation and boundary violations while telling myself it was love. I nearly died physically and spiritually before I learned the lesson: a man who will not kneel before God will eventually kneel before everything else – fear, resentment, manipulation, or despair. But the man who kneels? He rises dangerous to the darkness and useful to the Kingdom.

But the man who kneels? He rises dangerous to the darkness and useful to the Kingdom.

To all men reading these words – and to any man considering the fullness of the Catholic faith – hear this clearly: the time to start kneeling is now. Do not wait until the Valley has taken more than it should. The Catholic Church gives you everything you need: the sacraments, especially Confession and the Eucharist, the example of the saints, and the living Word of God.

This is a call the most masculine frame a man can adopt – to kneel before Christ first, then rise to rule your Three Kingdoms with ordered steel: the Spiritual Kingdom first and highest, the Kingdom of Sovereignty as the inner throne, and the Physical Kingdom as the forge where everything is tested and proven. None of it stands without this daily posture. The fire of the Forge does not consume the man who has already laid his pride at the foot of the Cross.

In the chapters ahead we will unpack the Three Kingdoms a man is called to rule. Yet none of it stands without this first posture. Spiritual Kingdom, Kingdom of Sovereignty, Physical Kingdom – all of them rest on the daily decision to bend the knee. The fire of the Forge does not consume the man who has already laid his pride on the altar. This chapter is not theory. It is the hinge. From the Valley of the Shadow through the Biblical Man, we arrive here: on our knees. Only from this place can we stand upright in the authority that God entrusts to those He has tested and refined.

Kneel before the King of Kings, humble yourself before his Bride the Catholic Church, embrace the sacraments and rise as a King to rule those Kingdoms to which you have been entrusted.

5.1 The Paradox of True Kingship

Today's culture loudly crowns its own kings – influencers, celebrities, and self-proclaimed alphas who strut across screens with perfect lighting, scripted outrage, and endless flexing. They promise dominance without discipline, pleasure without sacrifice, and status without surrender. Yet look closer and you see the truth: these are not kings at all. They are jesters in royal clothing – entertaining the crowd while remaining enslaved to the very appetites, algorithms, and approval they claim to master. Their thrones are built on sand. Their crowns are plastic. They bend the knee constantly — to trends, to lust, to cancellation, to the next hit of dopamine — but never to the living God.

A King does not wear the costume of the Jester.

True kingship is the opposite. It begins not with performance, but with prostration. The greatest King who ever walked the earth showed us the way. In the Garden of Gethsemane, Jesus knelt under the weight of what was to come. Sweat fell like drops of blood as He prayed, “Father, if you are willing, take this cup from me; yet not my will, but yours be done” (Luke 22:42). Hours later, the same King knelt again to wash the feet of the men who would soon betray or disavow Him. He who needed no one submitted Himself completely. And because He knelt in perfect obedience, He rose with authority that shook the foundations of hell itself.

This is the paradox at the heart of the Third Kind of Man. The world says strength means never bending. Scripture reveals that real strength flows from surrender. Saint Paul captures it beautifully in his letter to the Philippians:

“Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross. Therefore God has highly exalted him. . .” (Philippians 2:5–9).

The man who refuses to kneel will eventually kneel to something lesser – not as a king but as a jester. The man who kneels before the true King rises with steel that cannot be broken by the world. In my own life, this paradox became painfully clear after the recliner moment in July 2022. I had spent decades trying to be strong the world's way – carrying everything alone, lowering boundaries in the name of love, pretending the pain of each violation did not cut deep. Only when I finally knelt and asked, “Lord, tell me what to do and I will do it.” did the real forging begin. The answer was not conquest. It was obedience: bench, squat, deadlift. It was the beginning of learning that the path to sovereignty runs straight through surrender. This is the hinge on which everything turns.

5.2 Biblical Kings Who Knelt

True kingship has always been marked by the posture of the knees.

The greatest kings in Scripture were not those who stood tallest in their own strength, but those who willingly bowed lowest before God. Their greatness came not from refusing to bend, but from knowing exactly when — and to Whom — they must kneel.

King David, the man after God's own heart, shows us the pattern most clearly. He was a warrior, poet, and king who committed grave sins — adultery and murder. Yet when the prophet Nathan confronted him, David did not defend himself or rewrite reality. He fell on his face and cried out:

“Have mercy on me, O God, according to your steadfast love; according to your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions.” (Psalm 51:1)

He knelt in repentance, accepted the consequences, and because he knelt, he was restored. David's life was not defined by his falls, but by his willingness to rise again on his knees.

The Roman Centurion, a man of significant worldly power and authority, understood this paradox better than many Israelites. When his servant was dying, he sent word to Jesus: *“Lord, I am not worthy to have you come under my roof. But only say the word, and my servant will be healed.”* (Matthew 8:8)

A hardened military commander knelt in humility and faith before the Jewish carpenter. Jesus marveled at his faith and healed the servant instantly. Authority recognized true Authority.

King Solomon gives us one of the most majestic examples. At the dedication of the Temple he had built for the Lord, Solomon knelt before the entire assembly of Israel. With hands outstretched toward heaven, he prayed one of the longest and most powerful prayers recorded in Scripture (1 Kings 8:22-23). After finishing this prayer, Scripture tells us:

“When Solomon had finished saying all these prayers and supplications to the Lord, he rose up from before the altar of the Lord, where he had kneeling with his hands lifted up to the heavens.” (1 Kings 8:54)

The king of Israel, at the height of his power and glory, knelt publicly before God in front of his entire nation. This is the model of true kingship. Hezekiah knelt when facing impossible odds. Even the tax collector in Luke 18, a despised sinner, *“would not even lift up his eyes to heaven, but beat his breast, saying, ‘God, be merciful to me, a sinner!’”* — he went home justified.

Contrast these men with the kings who refused to kneel: Saul, who clung to pride and lost his kingdom; Herod, who demanded worship and murdered innocents; these are the Kings who hardened their hearts and eventually knelt before judgment instead of mercy.

The pattern is unmistakable. The kings who knelt before God rose in true authority. Those who refused to kneel eventually knelt in defeat. To the younger Catholic man reading this: Do not wait until you are broken like I was. Learn from King David, and the Centurion. Learn from Christ Himself, who knelt in the Garden and on the Cross. The culture will tell you that kneeling is weakness. The Church and Scripture declare it is the beginning of real strength.

A King who kneels before the King of Kings — then rises to rule his own kingdoms with ordered steel. This is how the Kingdom of Sovereignty arises.

5.3 The Meaning of the Black Marble Room

The dream of the black marble room stayed with me all these years — it was etched into my psyche. From time to time I would revisit it. I knew it was more than a dream; it was reality. Still, I struggled to understand its meaning. In particular, the phrase “we have decided to show you how this will end.” Who is “we”?

Then one night, well into my illness, I was reading the Book of Genesis and stopped at Genesis 1:26 — “And God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. . .’” Us. A plural. And again in Genesis 3:22.

The Log God said, "Behold, man has become like on of us, for he has knowledge of that which is good and that which is evil. Now, we must prevent him for reaching out and taking the fruit of the tree of life lest he eat it an live forever. "

The footnote explains that "us" is not a plural of majesty because that does exist in Hebrew. But rather, shows the divine process of deliberation as a consultation of God with himself. And with that it hit me "we" and "us", the Trinity: The Father, The Son, The Holy Spirit.

The footnote to Genesis 1:26 explained that this is not a plural of majesty (which does not exist in Hebrew), but rather shows the divine process of deliberation — God consulting with Himself.

In that moment it hit me: “We” is the Trinity — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, existing in perfect eternal communion.

The Black Marble Room was a prison of my own making, and the way out was beyond my grasp. Still, the Lord provided a bench to sit and think, and quiet reassurance that things would turn out okay. The dream was showing me, years before I was ready to hear it, that the way out of my marble prison was not force or self-reliance. It was kneeling. Submission to the King of Kings – the Triune God who exists in eternal relationship.

Only when I finally knelt — in the summer of 2022, in Confession, in daily prayer, and in obedience – was I able to rise and step forth out of my self-made prison.

That dream was preparation. It was God telling me in advance that true freedom, sovereignty, and steel come only through surrender to the relational God who made us in His image.

To the men reading this: Pay attention to the quiet promptings and symbolic moments God sends you. Do not wait until you’ve built your own marble prison. Start kneeling now. Submit yourself humbly to Christ and the communion of the Trinity. This is how the King that kneels begins to rule.

5.4 The Cost and Power of Kneeling

This is where many men break.

We want the crown without the kneeling. We want the steel without walking through the fire. We want sovereignty while still clutching control — especially in marriage, reputation, work, and our own image. I tried that path for decades. I played the happy fool. I absorbed accusation and boundary violations while telling myself it was love and

endurance. I nearly died physically and spiritually before I learned the hard lesson: a man who will not kneel before God will eventually kneel before everything else — fear, resentment, manipulation, the opinions of others, or despair.

The cost of refusing to kneel is immense.

It costs you your peace. It costs you your clarity of mind. It forces you to carry burdens and false guilt that were never yours to bear. It traps you in self-made prisons of marble and silence. Worst of all, it separates you from the only true source of power and freedom.

But the man who kneels? He rises with a power that cannot be taken away.

Kneeling before the King of Kings restores divine order. It breaks the chains of false guilt and gaslighting. It gives you the strength to hold frame without hatred. It equips you to love without being naive, to forgive without forgetting, and to enforce boundaries with calm clarity instead of rage or withdrawal.

This is the power that flows from surrender:

- The power to speak truth without needing validation.
- The power to lead your Three Kingdoms without becoming a tyrant or a doormat.
- The power to enter the Forge again and again, knowing the fire refines rather than destroys.

Do not wait until the cost becomes unbearable like it did for me. The culture screams that kneeling is weakness. The Church and Scripture declare it is the beginning of real masculine strength. Start now. Make Confession a regular practice. Receive the Eucharist with reverence. Spend time daily on your knees in prayer. Build the habit before the Valley forces you into it. The man who kneels before God rises dangerous to the darkness and useful to the Kingdom. He becomes the Third Kind of Man — tested, refined, and unbreakable.

From here, everything changes.

5.5 The Dawn of the Three Kingdoms

This is the turning point.

Everything that came before — the descent into the Valley, the refining fire of the Forge, the revelation of the Biblical Man, and the humble posture of the King who kneels — has led here.

Now something new begins.

From this place of surrender, the Third Kind of Man rises and begins to intentionally raise and rule his Three Kingdoms in divine order.

The long night in the Valley is ending. The refiner's fire has done its work, burning off the dross. The King is rising. Now the real reign begins.

Chapter 6

The Three Kingdoms as a Reflection of the Trinity

4 Hear O Israel, the Lord our God, is Lord alone. 5 You shall love the Lord, your God, with all your heart, all your soul, all your might. – Deuteronomy 6:4:5

19 "Go, therefore, and make disciples of all nations, baptizing in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit" – Matthew 28:19

Just as God is one God in three Persons (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) in perfect ordered communion, a man is called to live one life through three interconnected Kingdoms in proper order.

1. **The Spiritual Kingdom** – The Highest (reflects the Father – Source of Authority)

Inner Trinity:

- Prayer/Kneeling
- Sacraments – especially Confession and Eucharist
- Scripture and Obedience

The unshakable foundation and the throne above all thrones. This is The Catholic Church. Here a man kneels before the King of Kings and draws all authority, peace, and clarity from that holy communion with the Trinity. “Seek first the Kingdom of God and His righteousness...” (Matthew 6:33). Everything else flows from this relationship.

2. **Kingdom of Sovereignty** – The Inner Throne (reflects the Son – the Word, the obedient King)

Inner Trinity:

- Reclaimed Reality (truth over gaslighting)
- Frame and Boundaries ("no-bid")
- Self Possession and Emotional Regulation

Born directly from the Spiritual Kingdom, this is where a man reclaims his mind, his frame, and his reality. No more false guilt. No more rewritten history. No more

absorbing burdens that are not his to carry. Here he stands upright with steel in his spine and peace in his soul.

3. **Physical Kingdom** – The Forge (reflects the Holy Spirit – the active, sanctifying power in the world)

Inner Trinity:

- The weight room (Body)
- Marriage Sovereignty (Relationship)
- Daily Habits and Legacy (Work and Fruitfulness)

Only after the first two are properly raised and ordered can the Physical Kingdom become a true forge instead of a source of identity or idolatry. This is Iron Church. Body stewardship. Marriage Sovereignty. Daily habits. Work and Legacy. This is where the steel is tested and proven in the real world.

None of these three can stand without the daily decision to kneel. Invert the order and the structure collapses. Put the Physical Kingdom or Marriage first and you will eventually break. Put Sovereignty above the Spiritual and pride will destroy you.

A King who kneels before the King of Kings then rises to rule his own kingdoms with ordered steel.

This is how a man intentionally raises the Three Kingdoms.

Now the real reign begins.

Chapter 7

The Spiritual Kingdom

17 He exists before all things, and in Him all things hold together.
– Colossians 1:17

1 If the Lord does not build the house those who construct it
labor in vain – Psalm 127:

The Spiritual Kingdom is not one compartment of a man's life. Rather, it is the sovereignty of God's love, justice, and grace established within his heart – the throne above all thrones, the source from which every other authority, peace, and strength must flow. Jesus taught this with absolute clarity:

“Seek first the Kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.” (Matthew 6:33).

7.1 Establishing the Spiritual Kingdom

The spiritual kingdom is the realm where a man lives in conscious, daily communion with the Triune God – Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. It is marked by:

- **The Catholic Church** Active, reverent participation in the Catholic Church as a son in the household of God.
- **The Sacraments** Reconciliation (Penance/Confession). The practice through which sins committed after Baptism are confessed to a Priest and forgiven through Christ's absolution. The Eucharist and the Cup

21 *"Peace be with you,"* Jesus said to them again

"As the Father has sent me, so I send you."

22 After saying this he breathed on them again and said.

"Receive the Holy Spirit

23 *If you forgive anyone's sins,*

they are forgiven

If you retain anyone's sins,

they are retained." (John 20:21-23)

This happened on Easter Sunday evening, in the locked upper room. Jesus breathes on them – a deliberate act echoing God breathing life into Adam (Genesis 2:7). This

is the moment that Jesus institutes the Sacrament of Confession/Reconciliation. He give the Apostles the power to "forgive" or "retain" sins and by extension to their successors – the Bishops and Priests of the Catholic Church which represents the unbroken line of succession from the Apostles.

The power of the Catholic Clergy to forgive or retain sin is also found in the Gospels according to Matthew:

18 *"And I say to you: You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my Church, and the gates of the netherworld will not prevail against it".*

19 *"I will give you the keys to the Kingdom of Heaven. Whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in Heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loose in Heaven"* (Matthew 16:18-19)

The Catholic Church has always understood "binding and loosing" to include the authority to forgive or retain sins in confession.

- **Scripture and Obedience** Immersing the mind in the living Word of God. In doing so the cultural lies, gas lighting, and self-deception lose their power.

The Magisterium, the Pope and Bishops in communion with him, is the living teaching authority of the Catholic Church, guided by the Holy Spirit to authentically interpret Scripture and Sacred Texts. The Primary sources for the Magisterium's Interpretation:

1. The Catechism of the Catholic Church – this is the single best starting point and is searchable online at vatican.va
2. The Liturgy – The daily Mass readings and the way Scripture is proclaimed in the Church is itself a living interpretation.
3. Approved Catholic Bible and Commentary – Ignatius Catholic Bible Commentary, Navarre Bible, Haydock's Catholic Bible.
4. The Church Fathers and Church Doctor's – Saint Thomas Aquinas, Saint Augustine, Saint John Chrysostom, etc. These are highly trusted by the Magisterium.

As a practical matter if one wants the official Catholic understanding of a passage, first check the Catechism, then cross reference with a trusted Catholic study Bible or commentary. In all cases, avoid private interpretation or non-Catholic sources as your primary guide.

- **Pray the Rosary** – The Rosary is your primary Spiritual Weapon – pray it daily. Aside from the Rosary, daily prayer and adoration, recognizing that true power begins with surrender to Jesus Christ – the King of Kings.

The fruits of raising The Spiritual Kingdom – The Kingdom of God in one's life – interior peace, clarity, and discernment. A soul anchored in God is not easily shaken by the storms in one's personal life, marriage, health, culture, or personal failure.

This Kingdom reflects the Father as the Source of all authority (The Creator), the Son as the obedient King who models perfect surrender (The Redeemer), and the Holy Spirit as the active, sanctifying power that makes all things new.

7.2 Catholic Masculine Frame of the The Spiritual Kingdom

- **Monasticism and The Rule of St. Benedict (Ora et Labora):** Prayer and disciplined work as the daily rhythm of a holy life. Stability, obedience, and humility before God formed generations of strong, ordered men.
- **Ignatian Spirituality (St. Ignatius of Loyola):** The Spiritual Exercises — rigorous mental and spiritual training, discernment of spirits, and total surrender to God's will. Designed for men living and fighting in the world.
- **Opus Dei (St. Josemaría Escrivá):** Sanctification of ordinary life through constant prayer and awareness of God's presence in every moment. The call to become a contemplative in the midst of daily duties.

7.3 The Catholic Virtues in the Spiritual Kingdom

The Theological Virtues find their primary home here:

Faith – Trusting in God's reality above all cultural lies and personal pain.

Hope – Confidence in God's providence even when the Valley is dark.

Charity – Love of God above all things, which properly orders all other loves.

The Cardinal Virtue of Prudence also begins here – the ability to see reality clearly and act in accordance with truth rather than emotion or cultural pressure.

7.4 Living the Spiritual Kingdom Daily

The Spiritual Kingdom is built through consistent, concrete practices:

1. Begin each day on your knees — Rosary, morning prayer, and offering your day to God.
2. Regular Confession (at least monthly) to keep your reality clean.
3. Daily reading of Scripture, especially the Gospels and Psalms.
4. Weekly participation in the Eucharist as the source and summit of your life.
5. Examination of Conscience each evening to maintain interior honesty.

When the Spiritual Kingdom is first and rightly ordered, a man receives clarity, courage, peace, and authority that cannot be taken from him. When it is neglected or demoted, everything else becomes disordered — sovereignty erodes, the Physical Kingdom turns into an idol or a prison, and chaos reigns in the home and heart.

Do not wait until the Valley forces you here. Build the Spiritual Kingdom – The Kingdom of God – as the non-negotiable center of your life now. Make kneeling, prayer, Confession, and the Eucharist habitual. Everything else – your frame, your marriage, your body, your legacy — depends on this foundation.

The man who builds this Kingdom first becomes dangerous to the darkness because he is no longer controlled by it. He is free. He is ordered. He is steel.

Chapter 8

Kingdom of Sovereignty - The Inner Throne

9 I have given you a command. Be strong and be brave, do not be afraid or dismayed. I, the Lord, your God, will be with you wherever you go. – Joshua 1:9

A man who has knelt before the King of Kings is called to rise and rule his own life with ordered steel. The Kingdom of Sovereignty is that inner throne — the reclaimed mind, the steady frame, the unyielding grip on reality itself.

Too many men drift through life having quietly abdicated this throne. They absorb burdens that are not theirs to carry. They accept rewritten histories. They internalize false guilt and allow external narratives to define their worth, their past, and their future. The result is a slow erosion: confusion where there should be clarity, reactivity where there should be resolve, and a deep fatigue that no amount of physical effort can fully restore.

The path back begins with surrender — not to the world, but to God. Only from that posture of humility does true authority flow. The man who has knelt rises different. He sees the mechanisms that once controlled him: the subtle gaslighting, the emotional outsourcing of their partners – "just friends", the cultural demand that men absorb false blame so women need not examine their own choices and behavior. He refuses to participate any longer.

Reclaiming sovereignty is not selfishness. It is obedience – the necessary ordering of one's inner kingdom so that love, leadership, and legacy can flow outward without collapse. *"Above all else, guard your heart, for everything you do flows from it."* (Proverbs 4:23). The heart in this passage is not mere emotion — it is the seat of will, mind, and spirit. Guarding it means refusing to hand the keys to anyone who would distort truth. From the high throne of the Spiritual Kingdom flows the Inner Throne – the Kingdom of Sovereignty. Here a man learns to rule his own life with ordered steel. This kingdom is expressed through its own inner trinity, three interconnected realities that must be guarded and cultivated daily:

1. **Reclaimed Reality** – the commitment to live in truth rather than in the fog of gaslighting, false guilt, or rewritten history.

2. **Frame and Boundaries** – the calm, consistent “no-bid” posture that refuses to absorb what is not his to carry.
3. **Self-Possession** – the hard-won mastery of one’s emotions, thoughts, and responses so that he is no longer ruled by fear, accusation, or the approval of others.

These three are not separate practices but one unified reality. When a man kneels before the King of Kings, he is empowered to rise and rule this inner kingdom. Without it, the Physical Kingdom remains unstable. With it, he stands upright, clear-eyed, and free to forge a legacy of strength.

8.1 Reclaimed Reality

The first pillar of the Kingdom of Sovereignty is Reclaimed Reality — the deliberate choice to live in truth rather than in the fog of gaslighting, false guilt, or rewritten history. Modern culture loudly proclaims that men no longer lead because men are weak, emotionally immature, and unable to properly regulate themselves. This is a lie. Men are none of these things. Rather, modern culture has successfully convinced many men to surrender their sovereignty through two particularly damaging feminist ideals:

- **Men must submit to women (or at least yield leadership in the home and relationship).**

This is framed as “healthy partnership” or “mutuality,” but it directly contradicts the biblical order of headship. In practice it means the man’s frame is optional and the woman’s emotions, preferences, and desires take precedence. The result is a household without clear order, where the man is expected to defer to avoid conflict, leading to resentment, dead bedrooms, and loss of respect. A man who accepts this surrenders his God-given authority and becomes reactive rather than steady.

- **Men must step back to give women opportunity**

This narrative treats male presence, leadership, or success as inherently blocking women. Leadership is falsely presented as a participation trophy to be handed out rather than earned through responsibility. In the home, church, and culture, men are pressured to diminish their role so women can “rise.” True leadership is not given — it is earned first by accepting responsibility, from which authority naturally flows. When men step back out of guilt or social pressure, they abdicate their natural role as protector, provider, and leader. The fruit is disordered families and a society that punishes masculine initiative.

Modern culture often claims that two contradictory truths can exist at the same time — that male leadership is oppressive and that men must step back to “make space” for women; that men must submit to women for equality and that women are oppressed when men lead. This is not wisdom. It is the same relativism Socrates spent his life exposing. The sophists of his day taught that truth was whatever a person could argue persuasively, that justice and injustice were matters of opinion, and that a man could hold opposing ideas without contradiction. Socrates rejected this. Through relentless questioning he demonstrated that when two opposing claims are both declared true, one of them must be false — or the entire structure of reason collapses.

A man cannot simultaneously be called to lead his household under God and be told that leading is toxic. He cannot be told to accept responsibility, from which authority flows,

while also being told that accepting that responsibility makes him oppressive. These are not two coexisting truths. They are contradictions dressed up as enlightenment. When a man accepts both, he does not become more enlightened — he simply surrenders his sovereignty and his clarity.

Socrates chose death rather than live by lies. A man who would reclaim his inner throne must be willing to do the same: reject the comforting illusion that contradictory claims can both be true, and stand on what is actually real. He must kill the man he has been conditioned to be: the compliant nice guy who absorbs blame, yields frame, and steps back out of guilt; the man shaped by decades of cultural programming that told him his leadership is toxic and his strength is oppression. Only by putting that conditioned man to death can he rise as the Third Kind of Man — the one who has knelt before the King of Kings and now stands upright with ordered steel. This death is not the end of his masculinity. It is the necessary crucifixion of the false self so the true man, forged in the fire, can finally live.

True leadership is not tyranny; it is the calm, sacrificial exercise of God-given headship. A man who has reclaimed his sovereignty refuses to submit to disorder. He leads — not by force, but by unyielding frame rooted in truth and obedience to Christ. Reclaimed Reality begins when a man stops accepting the narrative handed to him and returns to the truth of who God says he is and what God has called him to do.

8.2 Frame and Boundaries

The second pillar of the Kingdom of Sovereignty is Frame and Boundaries — the calm, consistent “no-bid” posture that refuses to absorb what is not his to carry.

In our broader culture, a central challenge is that many women have been formed to refuse male leadership. Instead, they often demand male submission while maintaining a combative, argumentative, and disrespectful spirit. Under the banner of “equality,” society has taught that a man yielding his frame, absorbing false blame, and abandoning boundaries is the virtuous and loving thing to do. This pattern plays out in marriages as a microcosm of the larger culture: homes without clear order, relationships marked by emotional chaos, and men stripped of the authority God entrusted to them. The result is not partnership but disorder.

True leadership is not tyranny. It is the calm, sacrificial exercise of God-given headship. A man who has reclaimed his sovereignty refuses to submit to disorder — whether in the culture or in his home. He holds frame not out of pride, but out of obedience to Christ and love for those under his care. He establishes clear boundaries and will not negotiate on what is non-negotiable.

8.2.1 The Masculine Frame

Frame is the steady, unshakeable reality a man creates and maintains. It is the lens through which he sees the world and the standard by which he judges what enters his life. When a man holds frame, he does not allow external drama, accusations, or emotional storms to rewrite his understanding of truth, his role, or his worth. He remains the rock — calm, consistent, and anchored in God’s order rather than her feelings or cultural pressure.

Frame is held through the lens of Reclaimed Reality. A man sees clearly what is true, what is his responsibility, and what is not. From that clarity he refuses to JADE — he does not Justify, Argue, Defend, or Explain when tested. He simply remains the rock. This is especially important in the common push-pull cycle many men experience: criticism or disrespect (push), followed by withdrawal or silent treatment, then a pleasant “reset” (affection, niceness, or intimacy) designed to pull him back into the old dynamic without real accountability. By refusing to JADE, he starves the cycle of its fuel. He does not engage the drama, does not defend his worth, and does not negotiate on non-negotiables. This is not coldness or avoidance. It is self-possession in action. Frame is not something he forces on others. It is the steady reality he lives from, day after day, regardless of the tests that come.

8.2.2 Masculine Boundaries

Boundaries are the clear, non-negotiable lines that protect the order of his life and household. They are not walls to shut people out, but guardrails that define what he will and will not accept. Non-negotiable boundaries include truth (no gaslighting or rewritten history), respect (no contempt or public disrespect), and his God-given role as head (no demands that he submit or step back from leadership). A man with healthy boundaries does not absorb burdens that are not his to carry, nor does he negotiate on matters of order and truth.

Boundaries flow directly from a man’s frame. They are the practical expression of the reality he has reclaimed and the order he chooses to maintain. A strong frame naturally produces clear boundaries, and those boundaries are enforced through the same steady frame — by refusing to JADE when they are tested. When a man holds frame, he does not negotiate on non-negotiables, does not absorb what is not his to carry, and does not allow emotional storms or manipulation to move the lines he has drawn. Boundaries without frame become weak and negotiable. Frame without boundaries becomes abstract and ineffective. Together they create the structure that protects the household and the man’s inner throne.

8.2.3 No-Bid and Grey Rock

The practical foundation of strong frame and boundaries is the “no-bid” posture — the calm refusal to engage in emotional games, justifications, or drama. When tested with criticism, silent treatment, or indirect jabs, the man simply does not bid. He does not justify, argue, defend, or explain. He may respond with a short, neutral statement or simply continue with his own life and responsibilities. This is often paired with “grey rock” — becoming uninteresting and unresponsive to manipulation so the other person loses the emotional supply they seek. No-bid is not coldness. It is self-possession in action. It starves the cycle of its fuel and protects the man’s inner throne.

The practical foundation that binds frame and boundaries together is the “no-bid” posture — the calm refusal to engage in emotional games, justifications, drama, or negotiation. Often paired with “grey rock” (becoming deliberately uninteresting and unresponsive to manipulation), no-bid starves the cycle of its fuel. Without it, even the strongest frame and clearest boundaries eventually erode under persistent testing. At the heart of no-bid is a deeper truth: a man seeks validation from one source only — the King of Kings. Not from his wife. Not from his children. Not from culture or public opinion. When his worth

and identity are anchored solely in Christ, he is free to hold frame and enforce boundaries without fear of losing approval or connection. This is the steel core of sovereignty. He does not need her validation to remain the rock. He only needs obedience to the One who called him.

8.3 Self-Possession

The third pillar of the Kingdom of Sovereignty is Self-Possession — the hard-won mastery of one's emotions, thoughts, and responses so that a man is no longer ruled by fear, accusation, or the approval of others.

Whether a woman submits or not is ultimately her choice before God. A man's self-possession does not depend on her response. He does not rise or fall based on her willingness to follow. He stands firm because his authority flows from the King of Kings, not from her validation. This is the steel core of sovereignty: emotional regulation, calm clarity under pressure, and the refusal to be emotionally hijacked by drama, disrespect, or withdrawal of affection. Self-possession allows him to lead with love instead of reaction, to hold frame without bitterness, and to love his wife as Christ loved the Church — even when that love is not reciprocated in the moment. He remains the steady rock because he is anchored in something far greater than the marriage itself.

Self-Possession is the fruit of Reclaimed Reality and strong Frame and Boundaries. When a man has reclaimed truth and established clear guardrails for his life, he gains mastery over his own emotions, thoughts, and responses. He is no longer ruled by fear of her disapproval, the sting of false accusation, or the chaos of emotional storms. He does not need her validation to know who he is. He does not rise or fall based on her mood or the success of the latest reset. This is not numbness or detachment from love. It is the calm confidence of a man whose worth is anchored in the King of Kings. From this place of self-possession, he is free to love his wife sacrificially without being controlled by her, to lead his household with steady authority, and to forge a legacy that outlasts the temporary storms of marriage. Self-possession is the steel that makes the inner throne unbreakable.

This is the throne from which the Physical Kingdom is rightly ruled. Without sovereignty, the weight room becomes mere escape, marriage becomes exhausting management, and work becomes hollow survival. With it, each becomes an expression of ordered strength aligned with God's will. The man who reclaims his inner throne no longer lives as a reactive shadow of what culture told him he should be. He rises as the Third Kind of Man — tested in the fire, refined by surrender, and now standing upright with steel in his spine and peace in his soul. He leads his household, stewards his body, and forges his legacy not because the world grants him permission, but because the King of Kings has called him to it. This is sovereignty. This is freedom. This is the steel.

Chapter 9

The Physical Kingdom

“Do you not know that your bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are not your own; you were bought at a price. Therefore honor God with your bodies.” – 1 Corinthians 6:19-20

“Therefore, I urge you, brothers and sisters, in view of God’s mercy, to offer your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and pleasing to God — this is your true and proper worship.” – Romans 12:1

Only after the Spiritual Kingdom is established as the highest throne and the Kingdom of Sovereignty is reclaimed as the inner throne can the Physical Kingdom become a true Forge instead of a source of identity or idolatry. This is the Kingdom of the Body, Marriage, and Legacy — Iron Church in its fullest expression. It is where the steel forged in surrender, is tested, and proven in the real world. Like the others, the Physical Kingdom has its own inner trinity:

- **The Weight Room (Body)** – The daily discipline of strength, mobility, and stewardship of the temple God gave him.
- **Relationship Sovereignty** – Leading and stewarding all key relationships (marriage, family, business, and personal) with calm authority, clear boundaries, and sacrificial love.
- **Daily Habits and Legacy (Work and Fruitfulness)** – Faithful labor, wise stewardship, and building something that outlasts him.

When the first two kingdoms are rightly ordered, the Physical Kingdom becomes the place where faith and frame are made visible. The body is no longer an idol or a burden but a tool for obedience. Marriage is no longer management but a covenant forged in steel. Work and habits become the daily offering of a man who knows who he is in Christ. Invert this order and the structure collapses. Put the body or marriage first and the man will eventually break. Put sovereignty above the Spiritual and pride will destroy him. But when the order is correct, the Physical Kingdom becomes the forge where the Third Kind of Man is proven.

9.1 The Weight Room - "The Iron Church"

The daily discipline of strength, mobility, and stewardship of the temple God gave him

The Weight Room is the most visible expression of the Physical Kingdom. It is not an idol of vanity or escape, but "The Iron Church" – the place where a man offers his body as a living sacrifice.

Here he builds strength not for ego, but for resilience, protection, and obedience. Squats, deadlifts, presses, and carries become acts of worship and preparation. The body is trained to endure, to protect, and to carry out the work God has given him. A man who stewards his body well carries himself differently – with presence, confidence, and the quiet authority that comes from disciplined strength. This is not the pursuit of physical appearance for its own sake. Rather, it is the forging of a body capable of serving God, family, and mission for as long as he has breath.

9.2 Relationships

Leading and stewarding all key relationships with calm authority, clear boundaries, and sacrificial love.

Relationships Sovereignty is the art of leading well in every sphere — marriage as the primary covenant, family as the domestic church, business as the arena of faithful work, and personal friendships as iron sharpening iron. In marriage it means refusing to outsource headship or absorb false blame while loving sacrificially as Christ loved the Church. In family it means raising children with clear order and love, not as peers or emotional crutches. In business and personal relationships it means holding frame, speaking truth, and refusing to compromise integrity for approval. A man with Relationships Sovereignty does not manage people — he leads them. He does not chase validation — he offers steady, Christ-centered direction. This pillar stands only when the first two kingdoms are in order. Otherwise it collapses into people-pleasing or tyranny.

9.3 Daily Habits

Faithful labor, wise stewardship, and building something that outlasts him.

Daily Habits and Legacy is the long game of the Physical Kingdom. It is the steady rhythm of work done with excellence, habits that compound over years, and the intentional building of a legacy that honors God. This is not frantic hustle for status. It is faithful stewardship — showing up, doing the work, leaving things better than he found them. Whether in career, finances, home, or community, the man in the Physical Kingdom works as unto the Lord. He builds what will outlast him: a strong marriage, well-formed children, honest work, and a name remembered for integrity rather than worldly success. This is fruitfulness. This is the Physical Kingdom doing what it was made for — turning the raw material of life into something enduring and good.

Conclusion

Revelation 21:5 – “Behold, I make all things new.”

The locusts came. I cried out. God answered. The repayment is unfolding — one rep, one breath, one day at a time.